

SURVEY REPORT

Experiment 3

Survey Report on Emerging Trends in Low-Code Application Development

A study of eight leading low-code platforms, their current capabilities, and their trajectory toward AI-driven and agentic application development

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Abstract

Low-code application development has moved from a niche productivity tool to a mainstream pillar of enterprise software delivery. This report surveys eight representative low-code and no-code platforms - Microsoft Power Apps, OutSystems, Mendix, Appian, the Salesforce Platform, Zoho Creator, Google AppSheet and Bubble.io - examining what each platform currently offers, how its vendor is positioning it, and the direction each is taking as generative and agentic AI reshape the category. The findings show a consistent industry-wide shift: platforms are moving from visual drag-and-drop builders toward AI copilots that generate applications from natural language, and now toward agentic systems in which AI agents build, operate and improve software with human oversight rather than constant manual input.

1. Introduction

Low-code development platforms (LCDPs) allow professional developers and "citizen developers" to build software using visual, model-driven tools with minimal hand-written code. By reducing the need for specialised programming skills, these platforms compress development timelines, lower costs and widen the pool of people who can create business applications. Industry analysts estimate that the global low-code/no-code market has grown from roughly USD 13 billion in 2020 to over USD 60-65 billion in 2026, and project it will approach USD 90-95 billion by 2028, driven largely by acute developer shortages, pressure for rapid digital transformation, and the integration of generative AI directly into build tools.

This report has two goals. First, to document the present state of eight widely used low-code platforms that together span enterprise, SMB and no-code/prosumer segments. Second, to identify the common trends emerging across these platforms and to project where the low-code category is headed over the next few years. Diagrams and comparison tables are used throughout to make platform positioning and trend trajectories easier to evaluate at a glance.

2. Market Landscape and Methodology

The data and positioning summarised in this report were compiled from vendor product announcements, industry analyst commentary (including Gartner and Forrester coverage) and independent platform-comparison sources published through mid-2026. Figures on market size are approximate industry estimates intended to illustrate the scale and pace of growth rather than precise financial reporting.

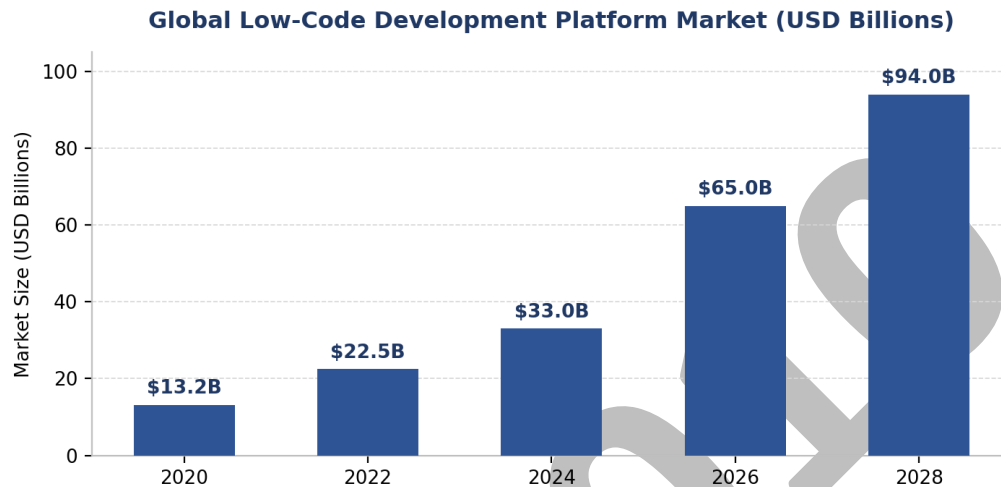


Figure 1: Approximate size of the global low-code development platform market, 2020-2028 (USD Billions).

Three structural forces explain this growth trajectory:

- **Developer scarcity:** organisations cannot hire enough professional developers to meet demand for internal and customer-facing applications, so visual tools extend limited engineering capacity.
- **Citizen development:** analysts estimate that a large majority of low-code users today sit outside formal IT departments, reflecting a deliberate push to let business users build their own tools under IT-defined guardrails.
- **Generative and agentic AI:** nearly every major vendor has embedded AI copilots and, increasingly, autonomous agents directly into the build and run experience, compressing the time from idea to working application.

3. Survey of Low-Code Platforms

The following eight platforms were selected to represent the breadth of the low-code category: four enterprise-grade platforms built for large, governed application portfolios (Power Apps, OutSystems, Mendix, Appian), one CRM-embedded platform (Salesforce), one SMB-oriented platform (Zoho Creator), and two no-code/prosumer platforms (Google AppSheet, Bubble.io).

1. Microsoft Power Apps (Power Platform)

Category	Enterprise low-code (Microsoft ecosystem)
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Current Focus: Power Apps remains one of the most widely deployed low-code platforms, tightly integrated with Dataverse, Microsoft 365 and Azure. Through 2025-2026 monthly releases, Microsoft has embedded Microsoft 365 Copilot directly inside model-driven and canvas apps, added natural-language "app skills" (data entry, exploration, visualisation and summarisation) and introduced an AI-first app builder that lets makers describe an application in plain English. Governance has kept pace through advanced connector policies and a Power Apps MCP Server that lets administrators supervise autonomous agents operating inside business apps.

Future Trajectory: Microsoft is steering Power Apps from a drag-and-drop canvas toward an agent-supervised environment: makers will increasingly describe outcomes, while Copilot and autonomous agents assemble the data model, logic and UI, with humans reviewing an "agent feed" of actions. Expect deeper Model Context Protocol (MCP) support so third-party AI tools (e.g., Cursor, Claude Code) can build directly against Dataverse.

2. OutSystems

Category	Enterprise high-productivity low-code / Agentic Systems Platform
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Current Focus: OutSystems has rebranded itself as an "Agentic Systems Platform" built on an Enterprise Context Graph. It now ships Mentor (AI pair-programmer for agentic app generation) and Agent Workbench (lifecycle management for AI agents), alongside native integration with AWS's Kiro agentic development environment and an AWS Transform pipeline for modernising legacy COBOL and Lotus Notes systems.

Future Trajectory: OutSystems is positioning itself around open, governed agentic orchestration - exposing Agent-to-Agent (A2A) and MCP tool interfaces so enterprises can build, govern and audit fleets of AI agents without vendor lock-in to a single LLM provider, while continuing to serve regulated, mission-critical application portfolios that require strict compliance and sovereignty controls.

3. Mendix (Siemens)

Category	Enterprise low-code for industrial and digital-twin applications
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Current Focus: Mendix, owned by Siemens, has moved beyond content generation to "executing logic" - using generative AI to scaffold data models, workflows and UI, while keeping professional developers in control of the security, scalability and architectural "final ten percent" that separates a demo from production software.

Future Trajectory: Mendix's own roadmap commentary frames 2026 as the year of "ecosystems of agents": developers become conductors who orchestrate multiple cooperating AI agents rather than writing every interaction by hand, extending Mendix further into industrial IoT, digital-twin and Siemens Xcelerator-linked manufacturing use cases.

4. Appian

Category	Enterprise process automation and orchestration platform
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Current Focus: Appian anchors AI inside governed business processes rather than exposing raw chat interfaces. Its April 2026 platform update introduced Appian Composer for AI-assisted, spec-driven development, and adopted the Model Context Protocol so AI agents can safely read and write enterprise data through Appian's data fabric while remaining subject to process-level guardrails.

Future Trajectory: Appian intends to let organisations track agent performance over time, feed that memory back into future decisions, and eventually let AI recommend and safely apply process improvements on its own - shifting Appian from a builder of process apps to an orchestrator of interoperable human, system and agent workflows across the enterprise.

5. Salesforce Platform (Lightning App Builder & Agentforce)

Category	CRM-embedded low-code and agentic AI platform
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Current Focus: Salesforce's low-code stack (Lightning App Builder, Flow Builder, Prediction Builder) sits underneath Agentforce, its agentic AI layer. The Spring '26 release added the Agentforce Builder for assembling AI agents with low-code tools, a natural-language "Setup with Agentforce" configuration mode, and an Agentforce DX MCP Server for wiring agents into external systems.

Future Trajectory: Salesforce is pushing Agentforce across the entire platform so that low-code assets (Flows, Apex, prompt templates) become callable "tools" for autonomous agents, blurring the line between building an app and building a digital labour force that operates on top of CRM data.

6. Zoho Creator

Category	SMB-focused low-code application platform
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Current Focus: Zoho Creator continues to serve small and mid-sized businesses with rapid form-and-workflow app development across web and mobile. Recent releases have centred on its Zia AI assistant – AI-assisted app creation, AI help inside the Deluge scripting language, expanded connectors, and enterprise security features such as bring-your-own-key encryption and multi-factor authentication for portal users.

Future Trajectory: Zoho is extending Zia-powered generation deeper into the build process (turning natural-language prompts into functioning forms and workflows) while broadening integration across the wider Zoho One suite, aiming to keep Creator competitive against AI-native prompt-to-app entrants without losing its low-cost, SMB-friendly positioning.

7. Google AppSheet

Category	No-code / low-code platform for spreadsheet- and database-driven apps
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Current Focus: AppSheet lets users build mobile and web apps on top of Google Sheets, Airtable or cloud databases without writing code, and remains deeply embedded in Google Workspace and Google Cloud. It is recognised for strong data-synchronisation and automation capabilities, though it depends on a pre-existing data source and offers comparatively limited visual customisation.

Future Trajectory: Expect tighter integration with Google's Gemini models for natural-language app generation and automation authoring, plus continued emphasis on Workspace-native distribution - positioning AppSheet as the fastest on-ramp for teams already living inside Google's productivity ecosystem rather than as a standalone enterprise platform.

8. Bubble.io

Category	No-code, full-stack visual platform for web and mobile applications
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Current Focus: Bubble is a fully visual, no-code platform capable of generating complete full-stack web applications, with native iOS/Android output sharing a common backend. Its 2026 Bubble AI Agent (beta) can create and edit UI, data types and workflows from natural-language prompts, troubleshoot issues, and explain how an app works, while the visual editor remains available for precise manual control.

Future Trajectory: Bubble is aiming to combine prompt-driven speed with the editability that pure AI code-generation tools often lack - continuing to invest in performance, native mobile compilation and its AI Agent so that founders and product teams can move from idea to production-ready SaaS without switching tools or exporting code.

4. Comparative Feature Matrix

Table 1 consolidates the eight platforms surveyed, positioning each by primary market segment, its headline AI capability as of 2026, and the type of team or project it best suits.

Table 1: Comparative overview of eight low-code platforms.

Platform	Primary Segment	Core 2026 AI Capability	Best Suited For
Microsoft Power Apps	Enterprise / Microsoft 365	Copilot-driven app skills & MCP agent feed	Enterprises on Microsoft stack
OutSystems	Enterprise / mission-critical	Mentor + Agent Workbench (agentic systems)	Regulated, high-scale applications
Mendix	Enterprise / industrial	AI-assisted logic generation, agent ecosystems	Manufacturing & Siemens-linked IoT
Appian	Enterprise process automation	Composer spec-driven dev + MCP data fabric	Complex regulated business processes
Salesforce Platform	CRM-embedded	Agentforce Builder & Agentforce DX MCP	Sales, service & marketing teams
Zoho Creator	SMB / mid-market	Zia AI app & Deluge code assistance	Cost-conscious SMB app teams
Google AppSheet	No-code / Workspace	Gemini-linked NL automation authoring	Google Workspace-centric teams
Bubble.io	No-code / full-stack SaaS	Bubble AI Agent for UI & workflow editing	Startups & founders building SaaS

Observed pattern: enterprise platforms (Power Apps, OutSystems, Mendix, Appian, Salesforce) are converging on agentic, MCP-based architectures that let AI agents act on governed data with audit trails, while SMB and no-code platforms (Zoho Creator, AppSheet, Bubble.io) are focused on making AI-assisted app generation faster and more accessible to non-technical builders.

5. Evolution of the Low-Code Paradigm

Across all eight platforms surveyed, the underlying build experience has evolved through four broad, overlapping stages, moving progressively from manual visual assembly toward AI systems that can plan and execute development tasks with human supervision.

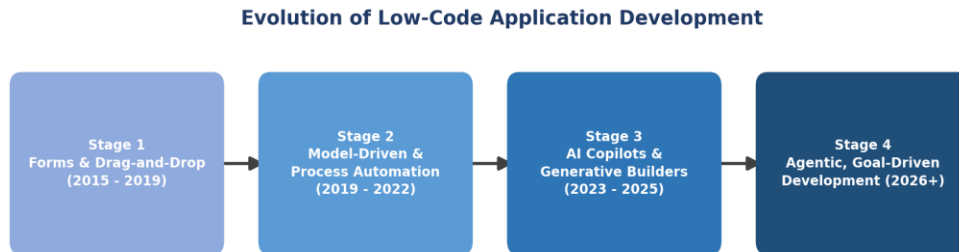


Figure 2: Four broad stages in the evolution of low-code application development.

Every platform surveyed in this report currently sits somewhere between Stage 3 (AI copilots and generative builders) and Stage 4 (agentic, goal-driven development). Enterprise vendors - OutSystems, Mendix, Appian and Microsoft - have moved furthest toward Stage 4, publishing explicit "agent workbench" or "agent orchestration" capabilities in 2026, while SMB and no-code vendors are still concentrating on making Stage 3 copilots more reliable and easier to use for non-technical builders.

6. Emerging Trends and Future Outlook

6.1 From Prompt-to-App to Goal-Driven Agents

Analysts including Forrester describe a likely path in which low-code platforms move from conversational app generation (describe an app, get a working prototype) to goal-driven agents that continuously build, test and refine workflows with limited human intervention. Several vendors surveyed here - Microsoft, OutSystems, Appian and Salesforce - have already shipped early versions of agent supervision consoles that let humans review and approve agent-driven changes.

6.2 Governance Becomes a First-Class Feature

As AI agents gain the ability to read and write production data, platforms are racing to add MCP-based tool interfaces, audit trails, connector policies and environment controls so that IT can set guardrails without slowing down business builders. This marks a shift away from the earlier trade-off between low-code speed and IT governance.

6.3 Legacy Modernisation as a Growth Driver

Several enterprise vendors are explicitly targeting legacy modernisation - for example, automated migration pipelines for COBOL and other ageing systems - positioning low-code platforms not only for new application development but as the delivery layer for replacing decades-old core systems.

6.4 Convergence of Low-Code and Hyperautomation

Industry forecasts anticipate that by the end of this decade, low-code platforms will be treated as a standard operating layer for enterprise software, with a large majority of mission-critical applications expected to depend on low-code tooling within a few years. This reflects a broader convergence of low-code development, robotic process automation and business process management into unified "composable enterprise" toolchains.

6.5 Continued Growth of the No-Code Segment

Alongside enterprise consolidation, no-code and prosumer platforms such as Bubble.io and AppSheet continue to grow quickly among startups and individual builders, aided by AI agents that can generate a working full-stack application from a short natural-language description - suggesting the market will keep serving both ends of the technical-skill spectrum rather than converging on a single tier of tool.

7. Conclusion

The eight platforms surveyed in this report illustrate that low-code development is no longer defined solely by drag-and-drop visual builders. Every major vendor examined - from enterprise-grade platforms like OutSystems, Mendix and Appian, to CRM-embedded Salesforce, to SMB-focused Zoho Creator, to no-code platforms AppSheet and Bubble.io - has embedded generative AI into its core build experience during 2025-2026, and most are actively building toward agentic systems in which AI does a growing share of the design, coding and testing work under human supervision. Organisations evaluating low-code platforms going forward should weigh not just current visual-development capability, but each vendor's roadmap for AI-assisted generation, agent governance and legacy modernisation, since these are becoming the primary differentiators in the category.

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